

Fourth Noble Truth: Noble Eightfold Path in Daily Life

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Daily life, the noble eightfold path.

As the retreat comes to an end, we naturally start to think about the bigger picture, family, friends, work and so on, and how we might bring the benefits of our retreat practice into everyday life.

To get the Buddha's advice on this, we have the fourth noble truth, the path to the end of suffering, with the injunction to follow this path for ourselves. The path itself has eight strands and is known as the Noble Eightfold Path. Noble because it is ennobling and it makes for a worthy life.

I'd been meditating for a few years before I really started taking this Eightfold Path to heart. Earlier I'd been so intent on learning to meditate I didn't take much notice of anything else in Buddhism. But finally the penny dropped. I realised there was so much more I could do, that there were lots of areas of life that could open up as part of spiritual practice. It was a great relief to realise this. I felt empowered and inspired. I hope it doesn't take any of you so long to open up to this teaching.

Each of the strands is described as right, right view, right attitude and so on. This can be off-putting as if there's no room for discussion or error. In practice, much of the path has to be discovered by trial and error, by considering, by experimenting, learning and discussing. But we're not in a sea of confusion either. We have these eight signposts to give us a sense of direction, a basis on which to learn and question and discuss.

It starts with right view or right understanding. This sounds dogmatic and the Buddha wasn't shy about stating his views as right, true, correct, while also saying that we have to investigate, see for ourselves whether they hold true in our own experience also. It's not a path of pure faith that we're following, but a path of wisdom.

Any form of Dhamma study will strengthen this aspect of the Eightfold Path. There are so many good books and after the retreat we'll provide a short list of some of our favourites. Or you could sign up for a magazine like Tricycle, which gives daily Dhamma bites into your email inbox and lots of excellent articles. Listen to Dhamma talks. Again, there are thousands to choose from. We have many on the Satipanya website and an excellent resource is the website Dhamma Seed, which has all the Gaia House talks, as well as those from IMS and other meditation centres. You could join a study program. There are many online courses available, including one that I offer twice a year at Sati Panya, usually lasting around

six weeks and based on some aspect of the Dhamma. Could be the four foundations for mindfulness, for example. Each week there are a set of notes with suggested exercises and people post their observations and reflections on a forum which gives way to learn from one another, which can often seem more believable than when it comes from a teacher. And Carl offers an online study programme, meeting monthly on Zoom to meditate and discuss the Dharma.

The second strand of the path is right attitude, which means cultivating an attitude of goodwill in the forms of compassion, generosity, kindness. For this, we have the practice of goodwill meditation, *mettā*. It's a good habit to finish daily meditation with about ten minutes of *mettā* and listen to a guided *mettā* practice regularly. Bhante Bodhidharma has one you can download from the Satipanya website, for example. And there are hundreds to choose from on Dhamma Seed.

We can also get into the habit of making good wishes regularly throughout the day. For example, if you're meeting with someone, spend a moment beforehand wishing them well in your heart. I'm sure you will find the meetings far more meaningful if you do that. As you go into a meeting at work, make a good wish that this will benefit the organisation, the people you serve. As you're sitting on a bus, you can wish well to those around you. I was on a loving kindness retreat with Sharon Salzberg, a renowned teacher, and she advised taking walks in nature, wishing well to the trees and bushes as we pass. A lovely practice.

I went through a very brief knitting craze a few years ago, and for every stitch I'd make a good wish for someone. There are no end of variations to the formal *mettā* practice and it's good fun trying them out.

A word of warning though. All the hindrances we come across in Vipassanā show up just as often in *mettā*. Sometimes we can't stop daydreaming, planning, writing a bestseller. Other times aversion shows up. We feel resentful instead of friendly. Else we doze off or get all fidgety and worried, or doubt this is doing any good to anyone. It's easy to compound the difficulty by assuming we must be a hard-hearted, mean-spirited person, incapable of love, totally unlovable. Instead, we should simply acknowledge that there's a hindrance afoot, and that we need to take it easy, be mindful for a while, rather than pressing ourselves for good wishes. After a while, it may be possible to return to *mettā*, but at a gentler pace, maybe a good wish at every third or fourth tree, every tenth passenger on the bus.

Mettā can be incredibly effective at repairing a bad relationship. I got off to a bad start with one particular colleague and dreaded every encounter. A friend reminded me to bring him to mind and say, may you be well, as I went about my other tasks. It might have helped that he went on a fortnight's holiday when I started this practice. But when he came back, I found myself relating to him quite easily. And in fact, we became friends as well as enjoying an easy and productive working relationship.

This strand of the Eightfold Path, Right Attitude, brings a lot of happiness into life.

The next three strands of the path concern morality, *sīla* in Pali, but before going through these, I want to show the role of kamma here, how it links morality and happiness.

When we hear of someone's good fortune, we might say, oh, that's your good kamma, and we might think along the same lines for misfortune, but this is a mistake. The Buddha said that karma was one of five laws operating in the universe. As well as the law of karma, we have the laws of the physical world, biology, psychology and finally the dharma, the four noble truths. We cannot ascribe someone's injury or handicap to bad karma. It could be due to biology, could be due to physics. Nor can we ascribe their beauty or longevity to good karma. These could be the biology of inheritance. What we can ascribe to their previous karma is a person's happiness or unhappiness. These operate under the law of karma.

When we think, speak or act motivated by greed, hatred or delusion, we sow karma seeds, which will eventually ripen to diminish our happiness. Conversely, thoughts of goodwill sow seeds of karma that ripen to make us happier. Sometimes the connection can be easily seen. For example, if we decide to give someone a present, then even the thought of this makes us feel happy. Often the process isn't immediate and can be quite subtle, so it can perhaps take years of careful observation to convince ourselves of the law of karma.

But we can see how it happens in broad terms. Motivated by ill will, we say something nasty. We might feel strong as a result, get our own way. So we get in the habit of nasty speech. Each callous remark confirms our position of power. But where does it lead in the longer term? Those of a kind and friendly nature avoid us or confront us openly. More fearful or conniving people, who like being on the good side of a bully, rally around, but will be delighted to stab us in the back when they get the opportunity. We don't have real friends. Deep down we know that, and so we live in a state of suppressed anxiety.

Similarly for greed, the enjoyment is temporary, while the stress of continually needing to satisfy our every need is exhausting, while overconsumption harms our bodies. And everything we consume has to be paid for, so we get stressed out with overwork. Satiating greed makes us feel needy rather than satisfied.

On the other hand, if we speak or act out of goodwill, there will be social benefits as others respond warmly to generosity and kindness. The benefits also go deep within. Each kind word helps heal our own heart. Each act of generosity counters our sense of neediness.

It is the motivation that matters for the law of karma. If a doctor cares for their patients only because of the status of the job and the amount they can charge, they suffer the consequences of greed, no matter how many people they cure.

Because morality, *sīla*, leads to happiness, we're not punishing ourselves by restraining our speech, actions or sexual behaviour. We're seeing that it's in our own best interest to speak and act with consideration for others.

The Buddha divides *Sīla* into three sections, right speech, action and livelihood.

Right speech must be kindly, truthful, timely and useful, as well as being said gently rather than harshly.

Sounds heavy going, as though you would have to think for ten minutes before saying anything. But as mindfulness practice deepens and we become more sensitive to subtle emotions, the rules become internalised as a gut feeling, because speech that doesn't meet these criteria leaves us feeling bad.

If we tell a lie, for example, some anxiety immediately starts up because there's always a danger we'll be found out. Shouting and swearing at someone might give some satisfaction when we're angry, but we find it much harder to let go of the anger afterwards and we'll probably come around to regretting our loss of temper. Idle gossip gives the thrill of titillation, but at our next meditation, we probably find our mind full of restless thoughts. On investigation, we see they link to regret, having spoken of someone behind their back.

That's the trouble with practising mindfulness. We just can't get away with bad behaviour anymore. It's because our nature is only at peace with itself when we're speaking and acting out of goodwill. The meanness or subtle cruelty that so easily accompanies lies or harsh speech or gossip grates against our true nature, gives us a hard time at meditation.

Speech is useful if it promotes happiness. You might wonder about small talk. How useful can it be to talk about the weather when we all know it's raining? But remember, it's the motivation that counts. Small talk promotes friendliness, helps us feel at ease. Very useful.

The main temptation towards unhelpful speech is gossip in the form of slander. Sometimes it can be difficult to draw the line between this and the genuine need to discuss a third party's behaviour. It could be because we've been hurt by the person and we need a kindly ear to help us move on. It could be because we've witnessed behaviour we judge as wrong and were troubled by this.

The historian Yuval Noah Harari argues that the main purpose for language development in early humans was so that they could gossip. This gave the tribe an advantage because if one of their members was untrustworthy, the rest of the tribe needed to know this, otherwise they couldn't maintain social cohesion.

If your motive is to do some good by relating a tale about a third party, then this isn't idle gossip or slander. You're protecting others from hurt or fraud. But we often have mixed motives. As well as the genuine wish to prevent harm, there could be strains of anger and vengeance mixed in with the gleeful titillation of speaking ill of someone behind their back. When I sense mixed motives in this or any other aspect of *Sīla*, then I make a good wish of the form, may I do more good than harm here. May I learn from any mistake.

Ideally, we'd confront the person directly rather than tell others of their behaviour. But this may not always be practical and might do more harm than good.

Timely speech is especially important when we have something difficult to say. Maybe you need to tell the person how hurt you were by something they did or said. If the other person looks exhausted or preoccupied, best hold back. It's easy for negativity to spread like a virus. It would be better to ask them to

meet to discuss something sensitive so that they would be more prepared for a genuine heart to heart.

Right action means not harming others, stealing their property or hurting through sexuality. While most of us would not want to kill or harm others, there is often some form of exploitation involved in the ways our food, clothing, gadgets and other goods are produced. In fact, it's impossible to be totally non-harming if you look into the matter seriously. But we can minimise harm by strategies such as purchasing ethically produced goods, avoiding factory farmed produce, becoming vegetarian or vegan, or becoming active in causes that support human rights, combat exploitation and poverty.

Not stealing. Few people who come on retreat will be involved in gross theft. But are we using more than our fair share of the earth's resources? Every manufactured item, every flight, every motorised journey adds to our carbon footprint. Are these justified? Do they benefit me? Do they benefit others? A challenging question for most of us, one we need to revisit regularly.

And then there's the thorny question of sexual behaviour. Sexual energy is powerful and can forge and maintain strong relationships, which might in turn sustain a family, a community. The benefits can spread far afield. On the flip side, infidelity can destroy all that, cause enormous hurt.

Abortion. How can we gauge the potential for suffering here? In Buddhist understanding, the foetus becomes conscious at the moment of conception, leaving no doubt that abortion is suffering from the foetus's point of view. But what suffering would be inflicted on a pregnant woman without the support and resources needed to bring a child into the world? No easy answers there.

And we have the horrors of childhood sexual abuse and vulnerable people being manipulated into giving sexual favours or forced into prostitution. Sexuality has the potential to enhance life, to bring great joy, to underpin social cohesion, but it can also cause enormous suffering. There will be big questions for many of us at some stage in life, which relationship to pursue, which to forego. But also more subtle questions such as, am I being friendly here or am I flirting? In a monastic setting, lay people are asked to dress modestly and not to wear makeup as a way of waking us up to the potential for manipulating others by accentuating our sexual allure.

The final strand of morality is right livelihood. The Buddha considered it wrong to make a living by dealing with weapons, poisons, slavery, intoxicants and meat. Although few poisons are sold legally nowadays, there is the tricky area of pest control. If your work involves these, see whether you could stock a compassionate alternative, like traps that do not kill the animal.

Butchery obviously involves great suffering for animals, and there can be long, frightening journeys before slaughter. To be directly involved in this must be a challenge to a sensitive heart and could foster indifference, even cruelty. Raising animals for slaughter is part of the same business. The Buddha's advice is to get out of this aspect of farming and anything else to do with the meat trade for your own spiritual welfare.

Many people are employed in the weapons industry, from soldiers on the ground to scientists in the lab. War seems horrific when seen from a distance. But can you stand by as atrocities are committed? It's a question of choosing the lesser evil. Bhante has an essay, *Is Armed Intervention Ever Justified?* It's on the Satipanya website and here he distinguishes between force and violence. Force is the energy used to put right what is wrong. Violence is the same energy laced with anger, revenge, spite and so on. Again, it's back to motivation.

The injunction not to deal with intoxicants poses hard questions, as almost every shop, restaurant and hotel is expected to supply alcohol. Most of us know people who live good lives while drinking moderately. On the other hand, many road accidents are alcohol related, as well as domestic and street violence and sexual abuse. If we can change job, then best do this. But that might bring its own problems if we let our family down or slide into unemployment and poverty.

Much of the hard work with Sīla is to decide which of our various options implies the lesser harm. For each of us, there will be difficult ethical questions to face at some stage in life. We need a clear mind to find the appropriate response and a stout heart to meet the challenge. We also need to be patient with our many mistakes, not torment ourselves about them, but remember we can learn to do better.

The last section of the Eightfold Path concerns meditation practice. This also has three strands, right effort, mindfulness and concentration. Every step we've looked at so far requires effort. The effort to speak truthfully, the effort to act kindly and so on.

It's also singled out as a factor of the Eightfold Path because we can cultivate this quality in our meditation practice. We do this by getting to know what effort feels like as a moment to moment experience. Are we slumping? If so, can we straighten up? Are we slacking, letting ourselves be carried away on every stray thought? If so, can we resolve to be mindful?

Over effort is a problem for many of us. We want to be enlightened now, this minute. Can we relax, remember this is a gradual path, and that we can learn to enjoy the journey? If we can't relax, can we feel the tensions? Let the experience of over effort itself become the focus for meditation.

As we stumble between slacking and over-effort, mindfulness guides us towards right effort, where we're alert and interested, but not hoping to gain anything from meditation. In time, that balance becomes more motivating than the false hopes of over effort or the dozy delight of slacking.

As we develop right effort in meditation, we can apply it in practice. First, we have the here and now effort to prevent harmful states like greed and ill will arising. If we maintain mindfulness, the hindrances don't get a chance to blossom and spread their seeds. It's as simple as that. But sadly, we forget to be mindful a lot of the time in daily life. It's often pain of one form or another that wakes us up. Pain, whether emotional or physical, can stir fear, anxiety, worry, anger, blame, despair. It's easy to make a bad situation worse.

If we can remember this strand of right effort—the need to prevent unwholesome states from arising—we will bring mindfulness to the forefront, contain the negativity, prevent the negative spiral. It's especially important to make this effort during a busy day. Otherwise, minor irritations and frustrations build up and we might end up saying something hurtful, spoiling a friendship.

We could follow the practice of three-minute breathing spaces, which are a part of Jon Kabat-Zinn's mindfulness-based stress reduction programme. First, we acknowledge how we feel, let the emotions settle as we track them mindfully. We then follow the breath for a minute and end by reminding ourselves of the larger picture and whatever task or activity it is we're about to resume as we move back into it mindfully.

We can also use right effort in the broader sense, choosing directions in life which will minimise laziness, aggression, meanness—all our worst characteristics—while encouraging our positive qualities. Many people report that life made a turn for the better when they started meditation practice and found *Sangha* friends, which naturally led to *Dhamma* study and regular retreats. These supportive conditions bring out the best in us, take the rough edges off our worst traits.

Finally, we have the here and now effort to develop and make the most of our wholesome qualities. Meditation is the key. *Vipassanā* strengthens equanimity, joy and all the factors of enlightenment, while *mettā* trains us to see the good in others and the good in ourselves.

Next we have right mindfulness, and for this I thought it would be interesting to go through the Buddhism Bites on full awareness in the teaching known as the Four Foundations of Mindfulness, the *Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta*. Here's the quotation: "One acts in full awareness when going forward and returning, when looking ahead and looking away, when flexing and extending the limbs, when eating, drinking, defecating and urinating, walking, standing, sitting, falling asleep, waking up, talking and keeping silent." Basically, we are to be fully aware in all aspects of life, every moment of every day.

Full awareness requires a broad understanding of our actions, as well as registering our moment to moment experience. Say we're walking to a neighbour's house. We could be mindful of the physical sensations of walking to keep us in the present moment. For full awareness, the context must also be borne in mind. We are going to visit our neighbour. While en route to work in the morning, we can remind ourselves regularly that we are indeed on our way to work, not to Shangri-La or wherever our daydreams are leading us.

Instead of the detailed noting we use for Mahāsi retreat practice, broad brush phrases work better here. We can note: going to work, going to work. Sounds obvious, but how easy it is to forget the bigger picture. We go to work on autopilot, so familiar with every step of the journey that we can devote our time to worrying or daydreaming. The note "going to work" lifts us out of the doldrums, lets us feel more purposeful, helps us appreciate our surroundings.

Within that broad awareness, we keep track of body movements like walking, reaching out, turning and so on. It can be a challenge to include inner and outer realities. At times we want to withdraw, abandon worldly cares, just breathe. At other times our attention is totally external, fascinated by whatever is happening around us. The challenge is to keep both worlds in mind, to include body awareness when entranced by the external world, to remember the broader context when our attention is pulled within.

Reminding ourselves of the broader context can expose hidden emotions. We might be reluctant to note "going to work," for example, but later in the day be quite happy to note "going home." The reluctance indicates some negativity about work. If we don't make the note, that negativity might later sneak out as coldness or irritation. Unwittingly, we alienate our colleagues and make the situation worse.

The note "going to work" shows us the weariness or anxiety or depression. Although it might feel worse than heading for the job on autopilot, bearing with the feelings means the negativity can be acknowledged. Imperceptibly, perhaps our working life gets easier as a result.

Even for less emotionally charged activities, the experience of going forward can differ from returning. Say I have to nip down to the shops for groceries. I'm often bright and purposeful on the way out. My step is light and I look with interest at the neighbour's garden. Coming home, my steps are more plodding, my eyes downcast. What I'm seeing here is the *dukkha* of transience. Each new activity offers a glimmer of hope that this world can make us happy. But when the choice between apples and oranges, biscuits and cake have been made and all the money spent, it becomes clear that my shopping spree has not delivered the goods I was secretly hoping for.

The pattern can vary. For instance, the prospect of meeting friends may find us brighter on the way home than heading out. It's worthwhile noting—it helps us to appreciate our friends when we see how they lift our mood.

The second task is to be fully aware when looking ahead and looking away. Looking ahead reminds us of our destination, our purpose, so it helps with the broad context aspect of full awareness. When we look at anything deliberately, we can also interpret this as looking ahead, even if our head is turning aside to look at something on our left or right.

While looking ahead is often stimulating, looking away often carries subtle *dukkha*. A friend practising mindfulness of speech found that her head turned slightly to one side when reacting against what another person was saying. Once she had detected the pattern, she was then able to use this as a wake-up call to notice aversion. Her communication could then be much more honest and straightforward.

Becoming mindful of looking ahead and away can tune us into the subtle *dukkha* of transience. Maybe the daffodils in a neighbour's garden take our fancy and we spend a moment looking at them. Then we look away, seeking out the next visual treat. Without registering it, we've tired of the daffodils. These persistent, minor disappointments promote cynicism. The world is full of false promises. Everything lets

us down in the end.

But if we prime ourselves to be mindful of looking ahead and looking away, we may notice a subtle expectation in the former and disappointment in the latter. Over time, we learn that expectation and disappointment are of our own making. It's much easier to appreciate daffodils when we expect less of them.

Our third task, flexing and extending the limbs, has less emotional significance. Instead, the action connects us with neutral experiences that we usually ignore. We flex and extend our limbs several times while we're washing, dressing, doing household chores, manual labour, opening doors, and numerous other tasks. As we become mindful of these movements, we add bodily awareness to daily life. The body offers a restful focus for a mind that so easily hits overdrive, making grandiose plans and assuming we can do ten things at once. If we put our bodies in the picture, we come down to earth and our plans and promises become more realistic.

Outside of retreat, eating mindfully is often a challenge. The first spoonful might be savoured, but by the second we're already taking out our mobile phones. I find the need to set clear red lines here. No phones, books or entertainment other than the pleasure of mindful eating. This develops an appreciation of joy or *muditā*, a joyful response to the good things in life.

Eating and drinking brings us to urinating and defecating. The activities themselves are usually neutral experiences. It is the thought of what's happening that gets us. The social taboo around these essential bodily functions can result in embarrassment and shame. The way out, of course, is to feel and acknowledge the emotional baggage. This totally unnecessary shame will start to burn out and we develop a healthy respect for the body's ability to discard its waste.

We can practise with the Buddha's guidance in many areas of daily life. During any journey, ideally from the start, we can pick a phrase like "going to the shops" and repeat this regularly. We can do the same on the way home, being curious as to whether the outward and homeward journeys feel the same or different.

We can take an interest in what our eyes are doing and any emotional undertones. Are they looking ahead? Is there a sense of expectancy, interest? Or are they looking away? Is there a quiet judgement, disinterest?

We can be mindful during communications, spotting when we feel hurt, bored or irritated by the conversation and when we feel buoyed up, interested or excited by the interaction.

The final strand in the Eightfold Path is Right Concentration. We need to make time for formal meditation practice, where the mind can come to stillness, rest in present awareness. For this, we need to develop a habit of regular daily meditation. Some prefer mornings, some prefer evenings. If you can do both, ideal. How long to meditate for? That really depends on your circumstances, how many other demands there

are on your time. If you can do an hour, excellent. But whatever is possible—forty minutes, thirty minutes, whatever you can manage.

It always helps if you can find support. Would anyone in your household meditate with you? Could you find a local group? The single most important factor in sustaining my meditation in the early years was the fact that I found a local group, got into the habit of meeting them every week for meditation and *Dhamma* study discussion as well. They soon became my best friends and supported many aspects of the Eightfold Path.

There are also lots of online options for support nowadays. For example, there is an online meditation hall that you can access via the Satipanya website. It's a Zoom link and open all day, but the only times you're likely to see others are 6am and 8pm. The 6am slot has an hour's meditation, followed by some chanting and *mettā* practice. The 8pm slot has meditation, followed by *mettā* and joy practices and chanting.

Retreats give the best support for developing concentration. We shut ourselves away from the world for a few days or a few weeks so that there isn't the continuous inflow of stimulation, views, demands, responsibilities that are part and parcel of everyday life. Retreat conditions give optimal support for right concentration. We learn to focus the mind, gather its energies, channel them in the direction of liberation.

Concentration is an unfortunate translation for the Pali word *samādhi*, which conveys a sense of restfulness rather than forcing. We're resting attention on some aspect of present experience. We have the analogy of a bee searching for honey. First, she has to track a flower as it bobs around. This represents the first stage of concentration when we're making an effort to bring attention back to the breath whenever the mind wanders.

Then the bee lands on the flower, is carried around by it, no longer has to make the effort to track. This is the second stage of concentration where our attention is riveted by the sensations and feelings of present experience. We no longer need that effort to direct attention. Mindfulness continues of its own accord. Just as the bee drinks nectar in these moments, we drink the nectar of direct experience, the intimate contact with reality. It's from direct experience that we learn the *Dhamma* for ourselves, convince ourselves of the Four Noble Truths and the other ways the Buddha expressed his understanding.

So do make time for retreats in your life. It can seem as though we're always too busy for this. When I was working full-time, I used to plan retreats well in advance—several months ahead when my diary was still empty. That way I could give my family plenty of notice and say a clear no to whatever other demands came in during that period, without letting people down.

I hope this resumé of the Noble Eightfold Path helps you to see that there are many areas in life that can be developed as spiritual practice. To come back to one thing: the importance of support. Do make an effort to find friends who also want to walk this path. This is *Sangha*, spiritual friendship. Real life friends are best, but online also works well. I have a friend who lives in India. We regularly exchange *Dhamma*

questions and comments by email.

Our friends influence us and we in turn influence them. When we get despondent, they encourage us. When we're trying to pick our way through some thorny moral issue, we have someone to talk it over with. When Ānanda, the Buddha's cousin and attendant, remarked that good friendship was half of the spiritual life, the Buddha replied that good friendship was the whole of spiritual life.

May we all find the friendship and support we need to follow the Eightfold Path in our relationships, our work and all aspects of life.

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